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Launching a Fintech Firm in Morocco: Landscape, Opportunities, and Global Roadmap

Morocco's fintech scene is growing rapidly but remains nascent. A picturesque Moroccan marketplace (e.g. Chefchaouen in the image below) underscores the country's **cash-first economy transitioning to digital**. Account ownership has surged from 29% of adults in 2017 to 44% by 2021 [1], reflecting major progress. Still, about **15 million Moroccans (especially women and rural residents)** lack bank accounts [2]. Mobile penetration is very high (≈137.5%) and internet access ~83% (2020) [3], so digital services have broad reach. The government has launched the **Morocco Fintech Center (MFC)** in 2025 as a "one-stop-shop" for startups [4] [5], and regulators are modernizing laws (e.g. data protection, digital signatures) to foster innovation. A young fintech ecosystem means one-person founders can **test ideas fast**, leveraging existing infrastructure and a supportive policy push.

Image: A busy street scene in Chefchaouen, Morocco. The country's cities blend traditional markets with modern commerce, illustrating the opportunity for digital finance to reach urban and rural customers alike.

1. Morocco's Fintech Landscape & Regulatory Environment

Morocco's financial system is **well-developed in banking**, but fintech is still emerging. The central bank (Bank Al-Maghrib) regulates all banking and payment services [6]. New entrants must obtain licenses if they handle public funds or payment transactions [7]. For example, only licensed banks may take deposits, while *payment institutions* can handle transfers and cash-in/cash-out by remote means [7]. Bank Al-Maghrib has introduced **supportive initiatives** – e.g. a "one-stop-shop" to guide fintechs on licensing and compliance [8] [4], and new laws (crowdfunding, digital trust services) to broaden fintech services [9]. The regulator stresses the need for an **open banking framework** to further innovation [10].

- **Fintech Hub and Support:** In 2025 Morocco launched the *Morocco Fintech Center*, backed by the Digital Transition Ministry and 15 banks [4] [5]. MFC provides mentoring, incubation, and regulatory guidance, aiming to turn Morocco into a fintech hub. This aligns with the National Financial Inclusion Strategy, which targets 50% account ownership by 2023 and 75% by 2030 [11].
- **Regulatory Framework:** Bank Al-Maghrib is the licensing authority for banks, financing firms, microfinance and payment providers [6] [7]. Moroccan law (Law 09-08) protects personal data and requires CNDP approval for data processing [12]. Sensitive data (especially financial data) must be hosted on servers *in Morocco* [13]. Banks already comply with GDPR standards, and Morocco is working toward full EU adequacy on data privacy [12] [14]. New digital trust laws (2020) authorize electronic signatures and documents, further enabling digital services [15].
- **Emerging Crypto Policy:** Cryptocurrencies have been banned since 2017, but in late 2024 the central bank announced a draft law to **regulate cryptoassets** [16]. It is also exploring a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) to advance inclusion [17]. These moves create future space for blockchain-based fintech (e.g. stablecoin remittances, tokenized lending) once rules are in place.
- **Market and Ecosystem:** Despite growth, Morocco only accounts for ~2% of Africa's ~2,500 fintech firms [18]. Many startups stall at the seed stage due to funding gaps and a conservative investor climate [19]. Nonetheless, Morocco's youth and entrepreneurs are enthusiastic (e.g. at tech events like GITEX Africa), and local banks are beginning to partner with fintechs [20]. Digital wallet usage (Inwi Money, Payit, etc.) and mobile banking apps are spreading [21] [22], reducing Morocco's traditional reliance on cash. The chart below summarizes key regulatory features:

Area	Key Points
Licensing	Banks take deposits; financing co's & microfinance offer loans but no deposits; licensed Payment Institutions handle transfers and wallets [7].
Banking Regulator	Bank Al-Maghrib oversees all banking/payment licenses and prudential rules [6]. It has set up a fintech "one-stop shop" and encourages open-banking for fintechs [8] [10].
Data & Privacy	Personal data processing must be declared to CNDP, with strict consent rules [12]. Sensitive financial data must stay onshore [13]. Morocco is aligning with EU GDPR.
Digital Trust (e-Sign)	Law 43-20 (2020) enables e-signatures and electronic contracts for banks and businesses [15].
Fintech Support	Morocco Fintech Center (2025) offers mentorship, incubation, and regulatory advice [4] [5]. Government aims for 1,000 certified tech startups by 2026.

2. Emerging Fintech Verticals & Technologies

Beyond basic payments, lending and neobanking, Morocco can explore **innovation-driven fintech niches**. Key verticals and enabling technologies include:

- **Insurtech:** Digital insurance platforms can offer micro-insurance (e.g. for agriculture or health) via mobile. AI can speed underwriting and claims processing. Usage-based insurance (pay-per-use car insurance) and automated claim bots are global trends.
- **WealthTech & Personal Finance:** Robo-advisors and AI-driven budgeting tools appeal to millennials. With low personal-investment rates, platforms for micro-investing, automated savings, or crypto-trading (once legal) could differentiate. AI-powered personal finance apps — e.g. smart budgeting or expense tracking — are projected to grow from $11.8B (2023) to $76.2B by 2033 [23].
- **RegTech & Compliance:** Fintechs must meet complex rules (AML/CFT, consumer protection, data laws). Automated compliance tools, KYC/identity verification services (biometric scans, digital IDs) can help fintechs and banks alike. (Morocco's data law demands CNDP approval for data processing [12], so secure data workflow tools will be needed.)
- **Blockchain & Crypto:** Once crypto-assets are legalized [16], Morocco-based startups could build crypto exchanges, stablecoin wallets or cross-border remittance services (leveraging the diaspora market [24]). Decentralized Finance (DeFi) platforms (lending, yield farming) are rebounding globally (DeFi market CAGR ~46.8% to 2032 [25]) and could eventually reach Morocco's savvy crypto users. Morocco's interest in a CBDC [17] also hints at future apps for CBDC payments.
- **Embedded Finance:** This trend — integrating financial services into non-financial apps — is booming. By 2030, embedded finance is projected to reach **$7.2 trillion** globally [26]. Moroccan fintech can partner with retailers or rideshares to offer embedded lending, insurance or payments. For instance, integrating point-of-sale loans or e-wallet payments directly into shopping or delivery apps (beyond today's digital wallets) can drive adoption.
- **Open Banking & API Banking:** The global fintech landscape is moving to open APIs. An initiative like the Open Finance African Group (launched 2024) underscores this shift. Worldwide open-banking users are expected to jump from 25M (2020) to 130M by 2024 [27]. Although Morocco has no formal open-banking mandate yet, savvy startups can use any bank APIs or build API layers for B2B financial services. This paves the way for services like account aggregation or "banking-as-a-service" modules.
- **Specialized Lending & Financing:** Innovative credit models (peer-to-peer lending, trade finance tech, invoice financing) can target SMEs and informals who lack collateral. Crowdfunding platforms (equity, real estate, projects) also fill a gap: Morocco recently enabled a legal framework for crowdfunding [9].
- **Green & Social Fintech:** With climate change concerns, green finance platforms (e.g. micro-loans for renewable energy projects) are emerging globally. Morocco's focus on climate and inclusion suggests opportunity for fintech that offer green mortgages or carbon-offset investment products.
- **Gig Economy & Freelance Fintech:** Apps tailored to gig workers (on-demand payments, expense tracking, micro-pensions) can address a growing segment. Similar models have succeeded in Southeast Asia and Africa.

Each of these verticals can leverage modern tech like **AI**, **blockchain**, and **mobile platforms**. For example, AI chatbots can handle customer service or credit screening, while blockchain can tokenize assets or secure transactions. The table below summarizes some promising niches:

Vertical / Tech	Opportunity / Use Case	Global Trend Example (cited)
Insurtech	Micro-insurance for farming/health, on-demand policies, AI-based claims.	Global insurtech funding rebounded in 2025 (90%↑ Q1) [28].
WealthTech	Robo-advisors, micro-investing apps, crypto trading platforms (post-legalization).	AI in personal finance market: \$11.8B→\$76.2B (2023–2033) [23].
RegTech / Cybersecurity	KYC/AML automation, GDPR compliance tools, fraud detection using ML.	AI fraud detection is a top priority in fintech [25].
Blockchain / Crypto	Crypto exchanges, DeFi lending, tokenization of assets, remittance/stablecoin apps.	Crypto law draft under review [16]; DeFi growing 46.8% CAGR [25].
Embedded Finance	In-app payments, credit or insurance embedded in e-commerce, telecom or gig platforms.	Embedded finance market to reach ~\$7.2T by 2030 [26].
Open Banking / APIs	Banking data aggregation, API-driven lending, BaaS (cards/accounts via APIs).	Active open banking users to grow 5× by 2024 [27].
Crowdfunding & Lending	Peer-to-peer lending platforms, equity/property crowdfunding for SMEs, freelance capital.	Moroccan law now allows crowdfunding [9].
Green Finance	Fintech platforms for climate-friendly loans, impact investing, carbon credits.	Queen Máxima highlighted green finance in Morocco (2023) [1].
Gig/Freelance Finance	Earned-wage apps, micro-pensions, expense apps for contractors.	Gig workers globally seeking fintech solutions; rising gig economy.

3. Initial Lean Projects: Low-Cost, High-Impact Ideas

A solo founder should pick **projects that solve real problems without heavy infrastructure**. By focusing on software and leveraging cloud services, even one person can launch these:

- **Personal Budgeting & AI Advisor (B2C):** A smartphone app (Arabic/Français) that uses AI chatbots to help users plan budgets, track spending and save. It could aggregate transactions (via Open Banking or manual entry) and give actionable tips. Monetize via a freemium model or partner bank referral fees. This taps the growing AI trend [23] and addresses financial literacy.
- **Micro-Invoice Generator for SMEs (B2B):** A simple web tool or mobile app that helps very small merchants generate and send digital invoices/receipts. It could also do basic bookkeeping. This requires minimal coding (could use no-code platforms) and meets a regulatory push toward e-invoicing. It empowers micro-enterprises to join formal finance and reduces cash usage.
- **Automated Salary Advance on Demand:** For gig workers or salaried staff, create a system (possibly via WhatsApp/USSD) that offers small wage advances based on days worked. This can use a

partnership with payroll providers or savings account data. Similar models exist in Africa; it offers relief to the cash-constrained.

- **Remittance Comparison & Mobile Top-Up App:** A small service (web/mobile) that compares remittance fees for Moroccans abroad (France, Spain, etc.) and allows sending money or mobile airtime loading. By affiliating with existing remittance/pay service APIs (like TransferWise or local players), this can be done cheaply and caters to the large diaspora market [24].
- **Freelancer Payment Collector (B2B2C):** A digital wallet or card-for-contractors service (target freelancers and consultants) that aggregates international payments and handles currency conversion. Can integrate with Stripe/PayPal for payouts. It addresses pain points of cross-border freelancers.
- **Online Gift/Bonus Card Platform:** A website where employers or families can purchase and distribute digital gift cards or bonuses for employees (usable at many merchants). This leverages embedded finance (prepaid card APIs) and requires little overhead.
- **Digital Credit Score via Alternative Data:** An app that builds simple credit scores from phone data or rent/payment history, to lend access to unbanked millennials. Using machine learning on phone usage patterns (with consent) can underwrite micro-loans via partner MFI. This uses AI and alternative data to finance those without formal credit.

Each project relies on **cloud computing, SaaS tools, and APIs** (e.g. AWS Lambda, Stripe, Plaid, ChatGPT API) to minimize startup costs. For example, using ChatGPT or open-source LLM for chatbots, leveraging no-code backend (like Firebase or Airtable) and ready payment APIs lets one developer create a product quickly. The key is to pick a narrow niche, test with early users, then iterate.

4. Target Market Segments

To gain traction, the firm should focus on **specific customer segments** that are underserved or high-potential:

- **Urban Millennials & Gen Z:** These tech-savvy, smartphone-centric youth demand digital convenience. They are early adopters of fintech apps (digital wallets, peer payments). With high mobile/internet penetration [3], this group can be reached via social media and app stores. Products like PFM apps or embedded services fit them.
- **Small & Medium Enterprises (SMEs):** Morocco's 600,000+ SMEs often lack streamlined banking or financing. Solutions like invoicing, digital payments, and financing (invoice factoring or micro-loans) can yield strong impact. Modern SMEs need e-commerce payment plugins and accounting tools; servicing them (B2B or B2B2C) can scale revenue.
- **Gig Economy Workers:** Ride-share drivers, delivery workers, and freelancers (especially in cities) lack traditional benefits. They need on-demand payroll access, cheap remittance tools, and micro-insurance. A solution targeting their irregular income (like instant pay apps or expense trackers) can capture this fast-growing labor segment.
- **Underserved Populations (Women & Rural):** About **15M Moroccans** remain unbanked [2] [29]. Women are especially underbanked (33% have accounts vs 56% of men [2]). Rural communities often rely on cash. Tailoring fintech in local languages (Darija) via mobile money or agent networks can tap this huge segment. For example, micro-savings, remittances, or micro-insurance for farmers. The government's inclusion targets suggest support (and potential subsidies) for solutions reaching these groups.

- **Diaspora & Remittance Recipients:** Morocco's diaspora (mainly in Europe) sends ~MAD 100.3 billion (~$10B) in 2024 [24] and $11.8B in 2023 [30]. Fintech apps that simplify remittances (lower fees, faster service) or allow diaspora users to manage family finances from abroad have a large market. Likewise, the families and merchants receiving these funds are customers for mobile wallets or payment services.
- **Middle-Class Consumers:** A growing urban middle class (especially women entering the workforce) has disposable income and is ripe for robo-advisory, digital lending, or lifestyle finance apps. Products like savings tools, digital insurance, and buy-now-pay-later for shoppers can find traction here.
- **Corporate & B2B Partners:** On the B2B side, traditional banks, telcos and retailers are partners and customers. For instance, a fintech could license its payment platform to a merchant chain, or offer white-label wallet solutions to telecom operators (like Inwi or Maroc Telecom's subsidiary). Partnering with large institutions (banks, major retailers, even government programs) can quickly expand reach.

Understanding these segments allows focused marketing and product design. For example, targeting **SMEs and millennials** might involve digital marketing and partnering with coworking hubs, while serving **rural/unbanked** might require USSD/SMS channels and agent networks.

5. Roadmap: Local Launch → Regional Growth → Global Scale

A phased strategy helps the solo founder grow systematically:

- **Phase 1 – Proof of Concept (Months 0–6):** Build a Minimum Viable Product for one market segment in Morocco (e.g. a budgeting app or small business tool). Operate lean: use freelancers or interns if needed. Join the Morocco Fintech Center or a local incubator for mentorship. Pilot with real users (friends, local SMBs) and iterate rapidly. Ensure the offering complies with local regulations (e.g. register with Bank Al-Maghrib if handling payments).
- **Phase 2 – Formalize & Scale Locally (Months 6–18):** Incorporate a legal entity in Morocco. If required, obtain a Payment Institution license or partner with a licensed bank. Focus on customer acquisition through partnerships (e.g. team up with a bank branch to pilot the service, or piggyback on a large employer to offer your service to employees). Begin monetization (subscription fees, transaction fees, etc.) and reinvest revenues. Hire a small team (developers, customer support) as the user base grows. Seek seed funding from Moroccan or international VC/angel networks aligned with Moroccan digital strategy.
- **Phase 3 – North Africa & Francophone Expansion (Year 2–3):** With a proven model, expand to neighboring markets. French-speaking African countries (Tunisia, Ivory Coast, Senegal) share cultural and regulatory similarities. Adapt the product (language/currency) and approach local fintech hubs. Use revenues or Series A funding to open a regional office or hire local reps. Integrate with regional payment systems (e.g. UEMOA zone) and comply with local regulations (e.g. CIMA in West Africa).
- **Phase 4 – Europe (Year 3–4):** Target Europe next, leveraging Morocco's large diaspora in France, Spain, etc. Establish an entity in an EU fintech hub (e.g. France, Malta or Cyprus) to access the Single Market. Comply with EU rules (GDPR, upcoming PSD3 and AI Act [31] [32]). Adapt offerings (maybe as APIs or B2B services) for European consumers or businesses. For example, offer Moroccan expats a digital wallet or remittance service that connects easily to Euro-based accounts. Pursue partnerships with European banks and fintechs (via initiatives like Visa Fast Track).

- **Phase 5 – Global (Year 4+):** Finally, scale to North America and Asia. In the US/Canada, target niche markets (e.g. Moroccan diaspora communities, or B2B services for companies doing business in MENA). This requires US MSB/Money Transmitter licenses or partnering with a compliance-savvy bank. In Asia, identify regions with cultural/market fit (maybe Middle East or Turkish markets, or even Southern Europe). Throughout, maintain the **“Morrocan DNA”** by keeping key services localized (support in local languages, understanding of Moroccan regulatory frameworks) while leveraging global technology and funding.

At each step, use **digital channels and strategic partnerships** to scale without heavy upfront investment. For example, pilot campaigns on Facebook/Google for customer acquisition, and partner with large retailers or fintech alliances for distribution. Over time, reinvest profits or raise successive funding rounds to hire local teams and build infrastructure (customer service, compliance). The timeline below summarizes major milestones:

Stage	Key Actions
Months 0–6	- Develop MVP targeting one segment in Morocco (e.g. student budget app). - Pilot with small users; gather feedback.
Months 6–18	- Incorporate company; secure any needed payment license or bank partnership. - Launch full product in Morocco; build user base. - Seek seed funding or grants; hire small team.
Years 2–3	- Enter neighboring markets (Maghreb/Sub-Saharan). - Adapt product (language, regulations) for Francophone Africa. - Form regional partnerships; local marketing.
Years 3–4	- Establish presence in Europe (e.g. France/Malta) to access EU market. - Localize product for EU rules (GDPR, PSD3 upcoming). - Target Moroccan diaspora and fintech alliances.
Year 5+	- Scale to global markets (North America, Asia) via partnerships. - Possibly launch additional products (e.g. B2B APIs) leveraging global tech trends.

6. Lean Tools, Platforms & Partnerships

To launch as a solo founder, leverage existing **cloud services and fintech platforms**:

- **Cloud & Dev Tools:** Use AWS, Google Cloud or Azure for hosting (many offer startup credits). Employ serverless or managed databases (Firebase, MongoDB Atlas) to avoid ops overhead. For application development, use frameworks (React Native/Flutter for mobile, Django/Rails for web) and consider low-code tools (Bubble, Webflow) for prototypes. Use GitHub and CI/CD pipelines for agile development.
- **Payment and Banking APIs:** Integrate with payment gateways like Stripe, PayPal or local equivalents (Payzone, M2T). For card issuing or accounts, consider BaaS providers (Railsbank, Treezor, Solarisbank) to avoid building banking infrastructure. Use OpenAPI/PSD2-like solutions (Plaid, TrueLayer) to connect user accounts for data (though Morocco lacks formal open-banking, global APIs may work via partner banks).
- **AI & Data Analytics:** Leverage AI/ML via cloud AI services or APIs (OpenAI GPT for chatbots, Google’s Vertex AI for custom models). Use analytics platforms (Google Analytics, Microsoft Power

BI, or open-source) to track user behavior and risk. Chatbot frameworks (Dialogflow, Microsoft Bot Framework) can automate customer support.
- **Communication & Engagement:** Use Twilio (or local SMS/USSD providers) for OTP, alerts and messaging. Implement email marketing (Mailchimp, SendGrid) and chat support (Intercom, Zendesk) on a lean basis. Social media scheduling tools (Buffer, Hootsuite) can amplify outreach.
- **Security & Compliance:** Employ third-party fraud and KYC services early. Use services like Onfido or Shufti Pro for identity verification. Leverage secure cloud IAM and encryption. Keep GDPR/CNDP compliance by using privacy-by-design tools and perhaps GDPR-ready CRM/DB.

Strategic partnerships greatly amplify impact without hiring a large team:
- **Banks & Financial Institutions:** Collaborate with local banks (e.g. CIH Bank, Attijari, Bank Al-Maghrib) for licensing, co-development or distribution. Global banks may join fintech hubs or offer sandbox programs.
- **Telecoms & Payment Networks:** Partner with Moroccan telcos (Inwi Money, Maroc Telecom/Orange) to tap their mobile money platforms or agent networks. Align with Visa and Mastercard's fintech programs for card issuance and investment.
- **Incubators & Investors:** Engage with fintech accelerators (UM6P Ventures, CDG Invest), government innovation programs (Digital 2026 strategy), and international investors (like AfricInvest or IFC). Joining the Morocco Fintech Center itself connects you to banks and regulators.
- **Technology Providers:** Work with global fintech services – e.g. cloud partners (AWS Activate), AI vendors (OpenAI startup license), or EU PSD2-API providers if expanding internationally. Use open-source fintech libraries (e.g. Bitcoin/crypto libraries) to jumpstart blockchain projects.
- **Academic & NGO links:** Collaborate with local universities or NGOs focusing on finance (e.g. Microfinance associations) for user testing and outreach, especially to rural/low-income segments.

By standing on the shoulders of existing platforms and alliances, the startup can **operate extremely lean**. For instance, using Stripe for payments and Twilio for SMS avoids building those systems from scratch. Likewise, leveraging accelerator mentorship and regulatory sandboxes (when available) will speed up development and ensure compliance.

7. Global Fintech Trends & Competitive Edge

Staying ahead requires adopting **cutting-edge technology trends** and aligning with global shifts:

- **Artificial Intelligence & ML:** Generative AI and machine learning are revolutionizing fintech – from **chatbot advisors** to fraud detection and credit scoring. For example, the EU's forthcoming AI Act (effective 2025) classifies AI fintech tools as high-risk, mandating rigorous risk management and transparency [31]. Investing in AI (for personalization, smart underwriting, predictive analytics) will be crucial, but also demands strong governance. Morocco's startup should plan AI features that can adapt to global rules (e.g. eliminating bias in credit models [31]).
- **Blockchain, DeFi & CBDC:** The surge in blockchain-based finance continues. Central Bank Digital Currencies and stablecoins are gaining traction: Juniper Research projects CBDC payments to skyrocket 2,430% by 2031 [33]. Morocco's interest in a CBDC [17] suggests future avenues. Moreover, as DeFi regulations emerge (AML directives, securities laws by 2025 [34]), a Moroccan fintech can build crypto services that comply early. For instance, tokenized assets or yield platforms can differentiate the startup. Security and compliance (KYC/AML) will be key as regulators tighten oversight [34].

- **Embedded Finance:** Embedding financial products inside non-financial apps will be a major edge. The idea that every business (retail, telecom, healthcare) can offer fintech services means new distribution channels. By partnering with commerce platforms or telecom apps, the fintech can "become the plumbing" for various transactions. The projected $7.2T embedded finance market by 2030 [26] shows how indispensable this integration is. For example, offering loans at the point of purchase in e-commerce apps or providing wallets inside social platforms can capture customers where they already spend time.
- **API Banking & Open Finance:** The global move toward open banking (EU's PSD3, UK's Open Banking, Africa's Open Finance Group) means banks expose data to fintech via APIs. The startup should architect its services as APIs, enabling future partnerships (e.g. other fintechs "plugging in" to your platform or vice versa). As Morocco and Africa embrace this trend, an API-first design gives flexibility. Notably, active open-banking users are expected to more than **quintuple by 2024** [27]. Building on this, the fintech can offer account-aggregation or payment initiation services in the future.
- **Cybersecurity & Trust:** With increasing digital fraud, robust security is non-negotiable. The firm must use strong encryption, multi-factor authentication, and real-time fraud monitoring. Complying with evolving regulations (Morocco's cybersecurity law, EU's PSD3 two-factor mandates [32]) will build customer trust. Also, digital ID initiatives (e.g. e-KYC using biometrics) can streamline onboarding.
- **Sustainability & ESG Fintech:** As global finance shifts to ESG, fintech solutions that enable green investing or carbon tracking can stand out. Morocco's green finance emphasis (noted by the UN Special Advocate) suggests market receptivity [1]. For example, an app that rounds up purchases to invest in local renewable projects or offers lower loan rates for eco-friendly businesses could attract a socially conscious segment.
- **Quantum Computing (Future Tech):** While still nascent, quantum computing promises faster data analysis and stronger security. Early R&D in quantum-safe cryptography or quantum-driven risk models [35] may offer a multi-year advantage. A forward-looking fintech founder should stay aware of these developments even if not immediately implementable.

By weaving these trends into its strategy – for instance, using AI for customer service while preparing for PSD3 compliance [32], or piloting blockchain pilots in line with Morocco's crypto roadmap [16] – the fintech can leapfrog competition. The integration of **AI, blockchain, embedded finance, and open APIs** will not only meet local needs but also make the startup globally competitive.

Sources: Industry reports and news from 2023–2025 provide insights on Morocco's fintech environment and global trends [6] [5] [31] [33] [26], including Moroccan regulatory publications and international analyses.

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